

Can God and Evil Coexist? The Logical and Evidential Problems of Evil

An original lesson plan inspired by **Michael Tooley's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on *The Problem of Evil*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Michael Tooley. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/evil/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Philosophy of Religion

“If God is all-powerful, all-knowing, and perfectly good, why does evil and suffering exist — and can any theistic answer avoid contradiction or just soften the blow?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the distinction between the logical problem of evil (Mackie) and the evidential problem of evil (Rowe), and state each in premise form.
- Apply at least two theodicies — the free will defense and the soul-making theodicy — to a specific case of suffering and assess how far each theodicy actually reaches.
- Evaluate whether the existence of evil is logically incompatible with theism or merely evidence against it, and defend a position with reference to a real-world case of suffering.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard for building an argument map of the logical vs. evidential problem
- Handout with the formal premises of Mackie's logical problem of evil and Rowe's evidential problem (the fawn burned in a forest fire)
- Index cards, one theodicy printed per card, for a sorting activity
- Timer for small-group and debate segments

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Earthquake Question

8 min

Present a real-world scenario: a devastating earthquake kills thousands of children with no warning. Ask students to write for two minutes, anonymously: if an all-powerful, all-good God exists, how do we explain God allowing this? Read a few responses aloud without judgment and list the "explanations" that emerge naturally on the board — you'll return to name these formally in the next step.

Direct Instruction: Two Versions of the Problem

15 min

Present Mackie's logical version: the claim that "God is omnipotent," "God is omnibenevolent," and "evil exists" cannot all be true together, since a perfectly good, all-powerful being would eliminate all the evil it could. Contrast this with Rowe's evidential version, using the fawn case: not a strict contradiction, but strong probabilistic evidence against theism, since some suffering appears to serve no greater good we can identify. Draw a two-column board diagram: logical (deductive, contradiction) versus evidential (probabilistic, weight of evidence).

Small-Group Theodicy Stress Test

20 min

Divide the class into three groups and assign each a theodicy: the free will defense (Plantinga — evil is the price of morally significant freedom), the soul-making theodicy (Hick — a world with real hardship is necessary for spiritual and moral growth), and skeptical theism (we should expect not to grasp God's reasons for permitting evil). Each group applies its theodicy to both the earthquake scenario and the fawn case, and identifies one case it handles well and one it seems to strain against.

Whole-Class Cross-Examination

12 min

Groups report their findings in turn. Push for direct engagement across groups — for instance, ask whether the free will defense can explain a natural disaster that involves no human moral choice at all, or whether skeptical theism, if applied consistently, would also undercut the theist's confidence in other claims about God's nature.

Closure: Return to the Earthquake

5 min

Revisit the anonymous opening responses and ask whether anyone's thinking changed. Exit ticket: which version of the problem — logical or evidential — do you find more forceful, and why?

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does the free will defense actually address natural evil like earthquakes and disease, or only moral evil caused by human choices?
- 2 Is Rowe right that some suffering appears "gratuitous" — serving no greater good we can identify — or does our inability to see the point just reflect the limits of our own understanding, as skeptical theism claims?
- 3 If skeptical theism is right that we can't know God's reasons for permitting evil, does that undermine other theistic arguments that do claim to know God's nature and purposes?
- 4 Would a world with real moral freedom but no capacity for the worst atrocities be conceivable — and if so, does that weaken the free will defense?
- 5 Does the sheer amount and distribution of suffering in the world matter to the argument, or only whether any single case of gratuitous suffering exists at all?

Assessment

Students write a two-paragraph argumentative response evaluating whether Rowe's evidential problem of evil (using the fawn case) succeeds against theism, engaging directly with one theodicy discussed in class and



explaining whether it blocks Rowe's inference to probable non-existence. Grade for whether the student accurately represents the theodicy's actual claims and directly engages the "gratuitous suffering" concept, not for which side they land on.

Extension Activity

Students research how one specific religious tradition — the Book of Job, Buddhist teachings on dukkha and karma, or process theology — responds to the problem of suffering, and write a one-page comparison memo explaining how that tradition's response is similar to or different from the theodicies covered in class.

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